

Session 2 prompt card

Use each prompt only at the stage shown in class. P1, P2 and P3 do not authorise an edit. P3-naive is intentionally under-constrained and is used only as a teaching example.

P0 Broad audit and fix

Audit this Excel workbook, find the errors and fix them.

P1 Decode the workbook

You are helping me review an Excel workbook before anyone relies on it. This is an inspection step only. Map the workbook from formulas and dependencies, not from sheet names or labels. For each sheet, state its purpose, its inputs, its calculation areas, its outputs, what it depends on and what depends on it. Distinguish declared source constants, same-sheet formulas, cross-sheet links, outputs and blank cells. List each formula family and the range it covers. List the definitions the workbook states about itself, documented exceptions and every assumption you make. For every blank, ask whether the workbook supplies the evidence required to calculate it. Do not infer or fill a missing predecessor. Map only. Do not conclude whether anything is correct or wrong. Do not propose or make any edit.

Excel Audit Assistant build prompt

I am a finance student and I do not know VBA.

Using the attached TargetCo_historical_model.xlsx and SESSION2_EXCEL_AUDIT_ASSISTANT_SPEC.md, produce one complete VBA standard-module implementation of the Excel Audit Assistant. It must satisfy every requirement in the specification. Do not give me pseudocode, partial procedures, placeholders or alternative versions. Use Public Sub AuditOpenTargetCo() as the macro I will run. Return, in this order: one complete VBA code block; the name of the macro I must run; a short table stating which workbook the code reads from and which workbook it writes to; exact installation and execution instructions for desktop Excel. TargetCo must never be edited, saved, renamed or closed by the macro. All findings must be written to a newly created report workbook. Do not choose an EBITDA treatment, fill Analyst disposition or apply any correction. Do not use Shell or system calls, network operations, file deletion or modification of any external file. If any requirement in the specification cannot be satisfied, tell me before giving the code.

Independent VBA review prompt

Act as an independent reviewer of the VBA below.

Use the attached SESSION2_EXCEL_AUDIT_ASSISTANT_SPEC.md as the required standard. Do not rewrite the code yet. Return a table with four columns: Requirement | PASS / FAIL / UNCLEAR | Evidence in the VBA | Required action. Check every requirement in the specification. In particular, identify every place where the VBA reads a workbook or cell; writes a value or formula; creates a workbook; saves, closes, renames or deletes anything; uses Shell, system, network or external-file operations; fills Analyst disposition; selects an EBITDA treatment; or applies a correction. Confirm whether all writes are restricted to a newly created report workbook and whether TargetCo remains read only. Finish with exactly one verdict: SAFE TO TEST ON A DISPOSABLE COPY or DO NOT RUN. If the verdict is DO NOT RUN, list the minimum changes required. Do not produce replacement code unless I ask.

P2 Classify the candidates

Use these four inputs: the Excel Audit Assistant report, the open unchanged TargetCo workbook, the explicit finance rules supplied below and the workbook's documented exceptions. Treat every Audit Assistant flag as a candidate, not a diagnosis. For every candidate return one row with: Candidate | Classification | Reason | Independent check | Downstream effect | Status. Status must be exactly one of: OBJECTIVE, EXCEPTION, OPEN JUDGEMENT or INSUFFICIENT EVIDENCE. Apply these finance rules: EBIT equals reported EBITDA less D&A; operating working capital equals trade receivables plus inventory less trade payables; net debt equals gross interest-bearing debt less eligible unrestricted cash; every net debt-to-EBITDA measure must use the EBITDA basis named in its label; the simplified free-cash-flow control must reconcile from tax-effected EBIT using the stated tax rate, D&A, CapEx and the change in operating working capital; revenue growth and same-period EBITDA margin are calibration checks. For each candidate, state an independent check that I can perform in Excel before accepting the proposed classification. Do not edit the workbook. Do not treat a candidate flag as proof of an error. Do not decide whether management's EBITDA adjustment is valid.

P3-naive Premature EBITDA decision

Based on the workbook and management's adjustment schedule, which EBITDA measure best represents TargetCo's sustainable operating performance? Choose the basis you would use and update the relevant metrics.

P3 Compare the EBITDA bases

Preserve two historical EBITDA bases. Basis A uses reported EBITDA. Basis B uses the full management-adjusted EBITDA supplied by management. For FY2024A and FY2025A, build and propagate both bases consistently through EBITDA, EBITDA margin, EBIT, net debt, net debt-to-EBITDA and free cash flow under the stated simplified control. Return one comparison table containing: Metric | FY2024A Basis A | FY2024A Basis B | Difference | FY2025A Basis A | FY2025A Basis B | Difference | Why it changes | Resolvable today? | Evidence needed. Calculate Difference as Basis B minus Basis A. Trace every formula to the historical workbook. Basis A must use reported EBITDA consistently and Basis B must use management-adjusted EBITDA consistently. A row is inconsistent if one component uses Basis A while another uses Basis B without an explicit analytical reason. For each difference, explain exactly why it changes or why it does not change. Use the supplied evidence to determine whether the underlying EBITDA treatment is resolvable today. If it is not, state the specific evidence required. Do not select one EBITDA basis as the approved treatment. Do not invent a partial or intermediate adjustment unsupported by evidence. Do not interpret Basis B free cash flow as additional historical cash generated by TargetCo. State explicitly the unresolved evidence that must be carried into Session 3.